extracted an annual revenue of not less than around ten million rupees from the Malwa province in the seventeenth century.[*]

The fertile belt of Malwa was a hen with the golden egg for the Tīmūrids. The rebellion had eclipsed this massive income and the attack on Malwa as well as Deccan had become inevitable. Two years before it, commander Khwaja Abu Hasan had invaded Malwa. These acts briefly led to the massive famine of 1630–32.[†] The destruction of crops in Malwa and Deccan by Shah Jahan's Regal armies has been well recorded by court chroniclers and foreign travellers. For example, Inayat Khān, in *Shah Jahanama*, talks about how Shah Jahan had ordered the imperial army to 'ravage the country from end to end'. The order of Shah Jahan was carried very comprehensively, and Inayat writes, 'There is scarcely a vestige of cultivation left in this country'. Like his ancestors, Shah Jahan didn't leave his wives during the war campaigns. And it was during his campaign of Burhanpur that Mumtaz Mahal died from a post-partum haemorrhage while struggling to give birth to their fourteenth child. She suffered around thirty hours of labour. And it was here that he decided to dedicate the tomb to her corpse which is known to the world as the Taj Mahal.[‡] [§] On the other hand, Shah Jahan's campaigns were of course set to bring results. The scarcity of rain when coupled with devastations brought by the Imperial Tīmūrid Army added to the great famine of 1630–32. The regions affected were Gujarat, Malwa and Deccan.

Just to set a perspective, we read about the devastating Bengal famine of 1943, in which three million people were killed, and for which Winston Churchill was held accountable. Yet, the Deccan famine of 1630–32, which killed more than twice that of the Bengal famine, gets whitewashed at ease. And of course, even if we hear few murmurs of famine, no one asks, 'Why did Shah Jahan kill so many?'

I was shaken after reading the agony of people and surprisingly court chronicler Abdul Hamid Lahori didn't roll a carpet over it:[*]

> Inhabitants were reduced to the direst extremity. Life was offered for a loaf, but none would buy. Dog's flesh was sold for goat flesh. The pounded bones of the dead were mixed in flour and sold. Men began to devour each other, and the flesh of a son was preferred to his love. The number of deaths caused obstructions in the roads. Those lands which had been famous for fertility and plenty of resources retain no traces of production.

Peter Mundy, the seventeenth-century British traveller and merchant who visited the region during the famine, wrote in his diary:[†]